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Effectiveness of student academic presentations: What do we learn from presentation guidebooks?

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ABSTRACT

This research is based on a survey of recently published presentation guidebooks designed for both general academic readership as well as scientific and technical communities. The primary objectives were 1) to examine how Anglophone academic culture views *effectiveness* of academic presentations and, respectively, determine the shared core principles which contribute to it; 2) to identify additional explicitly stated aspects of *effective* presentations, both general and/or area-specific; 3) to get a better sense of the generalizability of the language recommendations in the guidebooks by looking into whether they were derived from large language data sources or were based primarily on the authors' subjective language observations.

Overall, the survey revealed that Anglophone academic culture has a consistent view of several core principles on which *effective* and *successful* academic presentations should be built. The guidebooks also offered a shared set of additional characteristics, associated with both the preparation and delivery stage of *effective* presentations. However, the majority of the surveyed guidebooks lacked in the depth and breadth of their treatment of the language use in presentations. The findings of the survey can be beneficial to instructors and novice presenters alike.

1. Introduction

Compared to academic writing, student academic presentations are less frequently addressed and used as a learning opportunity at all levels of higher education (Author, 2012; Bankowski, 2010). However, in the last couple of decades, the interest in academicpresentations as a genre and academic sub-register has noticeably increased, perhaps, because both students and instructors have come to realize that presentations not only bring learning benefits, but they also equip students with skills that are increasingly valued professionally (Author, 2009, 2012, 2020; Chivers & Shoolbred, 2007; Dannels, 2003; Jiang and Qiu, 2022; Van Emden & Becker, 2004). As Van Emden and Becker (2004) put it succinctly:

> "The ability to present a case clearly, cogently and confidently is enormously valuable at every stage of students' lives, whatever the subjects they study; it will bring them success in academic work, job interviews and their future working life – it's the most transferable of all their skills, and a critical part of their professional development." (p. vii)

However, even though the *effectiveness* of academic presentations is often at the center of research arguments about the value of presentations, it is still somewhat unclear what specifically it is associated with. Thus, the impression that there is some common understanding of qualities like "effective," "successful," "dazzling," or "perfect" describing presentations in many presentation

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guidebooks seems more like a promotional marketing strategy than a clear or shared notion. In reality, the vagueness of those otherwise desirable qualities of presentations is the norm rather than the exception.

This state of affairs seems to prompt the question of what makes presentations *effective* from an Anglophone academic culture point of view since *effectiveness* is a more nuanced rather than a straightforward notion. Also, given that academic presentations are a speech event designed for an audience and delivered to an audience, it is logical to expect that language contributes to their *effectiveness* to a large extent. In that sense, it would be useful to know what the sources of the language recommendations are in the presentation guidebooks and whether they are data-based or mostly limited to the authors' personal experiences with the language used in this context. By surveying a mix of general and area-specific recently published guidebooks on academic presentations, my hope is not only to provide some "content" of the notion of *effective* and *successful* presentations as perceived by Anglophone academic culture but also to synthesize some of the desirable characteristics which contribute to it. To my knowledge, such surveys are scarce, which leaves most instructors in different disciplinary areas or English for academic purposes (EAP) and English for specific academic purposes (ESAP) to rely primarily on their personal experience with presentations or their familiarity with presentation recommendations (Author, 2020; Bankowski, 2010). Thus, one of the intended purposes of the current survey is to help instructors target explicitly the qualities commonly associated with the notion of *effective* presentations in Anglophone academic culture when teaching presentation competencies to both English native-speaking (L1) and second language (L2) users.

The rest of the paper discusses the findings from the survey with a focus on three main aspects: 1) the core principles of *effective* academic presentations, 2) shared additional characteristics contributing to the *effectiveness* of presentations, and 3) the source/s of language recommendations offered in the guidebooks. The survey was carried out from a listener accommodation perspective, which means that aspects of academic presentations that are primarily speaker-oriented (e.g., topic selection, public speaking skills, vocal projection, the use of relaxation techniques) are left out of this discussion. I should also add a caveat here that the survey is, by no means, comprehensive. Rather, the intention is to provide an initial overview of how recently published guidebooks treat the notion of *successful* or *effective* student academic presentations in Anglophone academic culture with respect to the three areas of interest noted above.

2. Description of the presentation guidebooks included in the survey

Guidebooks on developing the skills for designing and delivering *effective* or *successful* presentations are plenty on the market. While all of them target novice or inexperienced presenters, some are designed for professional readerships (i.e., people who need to give presentations on the job) and others target primarily students who may need to develop presentation competences or hone their presentation skills while completing their college degree. It is important to recognize this difference because, when the promised ideal presentations are qualified as *effective* or *successful*, the understanding of those qualities depends on the reading audience the guidebooks are targeting. For example, presentation guidebooks designed for readers who are already working in various professional settings (e.g., business, sales, management, engineering, technology) regard a *successful* presentation to be one that makes people act on the information they have been presented with or one that changes the world "or at least your little bit of it" (Raybould, 2015, ix). In academia, on the other hand, student presentations are primarily utilized as an effective learning task, and one of their main purposes is to encourage students to learn and use the communication conventions of their discipline so that they sound professional and discipline-appropriate when giving a presentation (Author, 2020; Dannels, 2003). Thus, the complexities and the expectations for students' presentations (undergraduate and graduate alike) are different compared to professional presentations given on the job. Respectively, the notion of *effectiveness* is different in many ways in those two contexts.

The current survey focuses only on the characteristic features that Anglophone academic culture recommends as desirable in academic presentations. Five main criteria were applied to the selection of the sources included in the survey: 1) the presentation sources had to be written and originally published in English; 2) they had to be published between 2000 and present day; 3) their targeted reading audience had to be primarily university students in Anglophone academic culture (among other potential readers); 4) their focus needed to be on giving academic presentations rather than on public speaking in general; 5) the sources had to be designed for developing students' presentation skills in several broad academic areas (e.g., humanities, social sciences, technology, engineering).

Thus, the presentation guidebooks included in the survey ($N = 15$) were all published in English between 2002 and 2021. To identify them, I searched all library databases to which the university has access, including WorldCat by using search terms like "academic presentation," "student academic presentation," "student presentation," "scientific presentation" and "science presentation." The books identified as relevant for the survey slightly varied in their targeted reading audiences, but they were all designed primarily for student presenters (among other potentially interested readers). About half of them ($n = 8$) were designed for a general academic audience (i.e., Chivers & Shoolbred, 2007; Engleberg & Daly, 2005; Levin & Topping, 2006; McCarthy & Hatcher, 2002; Reinhart, 2002; Raybould, 2015; Schwabish, 2017; Van Emden & Becker, 2004). The rest of the guidebooks ($n = 7$) were designed mainly for area-specific scientific and technical communities (i.e., Anholt, 2006; Carter, 2021; Davis et al., 2012; Krantz, 2017; Patience et al., 2015; Platow, 2002; Silyn-Roberts, 2002).

Per the authors' descriptions, the majority of the surveyed guidebooks were primarily written for university students whose native language is English and who study in Anglophone academic contexts. However, most authors mentioned that students for whom English is a second/subsequent language (ESL) would also benefit from the advice and recommendations they had provided. Reinhart's (2002) guidebook was the only one specifically written for advanced ESL students, preparing to study in English-based higher education institutions. Krantz (2017) also partly targeted international student readers who are in technical fields. Both authors, though, commented that their guidebooks could be successfully used with L1 and ESL readers alike.

Finally, four of the surveyed guidebooks (Carter, 2021; Davis et al., 2012; Patience et al., 2015; Silyn-Roberts, 2002) had a focus both on technical writing and academic speech, including presentations. Those sources were included in the survey because the relationship between academic writing and speaking is undeniable, especially from the point of view of what Swales (2004) has called "genre chains" (p. 22–23)—i.e., a logical sequences of genres which usually build upon each other. For example, if we take a technical field of study, some research into a technical issue may lead to the writing of a technical report; the technical report may result in a presentation about possible technical solutions; the presentation may lead to the writing of a grant proposal or business plan to secure funding for the prosed technical solutions, etc. Thus, combining the discussion about disciplinary writing with academic presentations highlights a logical connection between oral and written academic prose, which may go unnoticed in guidebooks focusing singularly on writing or academic speech. At the same time, the combined focus of the included sources also allows to emphasize important differences between academic writing and speech which may not be obvious or intuitive to novice presenters.

3. Method

To accomplish the three main objectives of the survey, I read and manually annotated the selected presentation guidebooks. I had access to the sources in three formats: hardcopies, electronic access, or hybrid access (i.e., in both formats). The patterns of what characteristics were considered to make presentations *effective* and/or *successful* were determined based on the explicit statement of those qualities in the surveyed sources. That is, the authors had to use *effective, effectively, successful, successfully* in reference to those qualities either in the local or the larger context of the characteristic they described. In the rare occasion, when an author used those keywords very sparingly in their guidebook, synonyms like *compelling, convincing, essential, outstanding, powerful*, *strong* were considered. Additionally, the authors also needed to offer an explanation about how the characteristic contributed to the *effectiveness* of a presentation. The example below, which comes from Carter's guidebook (2021, p. 9), is annotated to illustrate how the two identification criteria were applied:

> In fact, many of the most memorable, <u>effective</u> presentations (explicit reference) are also the most <u>focused</u> (a characteristic feature that contributes to the effectiveness of a presentation). <u>They resonate with audiences, sometimes long after they are presented, because everything in them is important and impactful</u> (explanation about how the characteristic contributes to the effectiveness of the presentation).

Recommendations that were not explicitly marked by the authors of the guidebooks as contributing to the *effectiveness* and/or *success* of presentations were considered to be more like secondary rather than primary contributors to their *effectiveness.* Hence, they were not accounted for in the observation patterns. Also, instances of vague uses of *effective*, *effectively*, *successful*, *successfully* in the guidebooks (i.e., uses without a prior or subsequent explanation of what, for example, *effective* refers to) were not included in the analysis (e.g., "Experienced speakers probably only need a good outline to prepare and give an effective presentation" (Krantz, 2017, p. 10).

Once all sources were analyzed, the observed patterns were categorized along two categories—i.e., 1) core principles (if all of the reviewed sources identified and noted them as fundamentals of *effective* presentations and 2) additional aspects of *effective* presentations if the characteristics were brought up in some sources (at minimum, two guidebooks) but not in others.

4. Core principles of *effective* academic presentations

Even though the surveyed sources targeted either a general academic readership or readers from a number of different disciplinary areas, there were several commonalities that they all addressed as core principles of *effective* and *successful* presentations. Those commonalities suggested that the presentation as a genre in the Anglophone academic culture is conventionalized to a large extent, hence, the core principles can be considered fundamental to the development of *effective* presentations regardless of disciplinary orientation. In what follows, I will briefly discuss the common core principles of *effective* presentations found in the surveyed sources.

First, all of the reviewed sources referred to two connected, yet distinct, stages in the development of academic presentations—the stage of preparation and the stage of delivery. However, they were not unanimous on whether one stage is more important than the other, though most agreed that *successful* presentations heavily depend on the preparation stage. Perhaps, this is because, at this stage, all speaker- and listener-oriented decisions are made to ensure that a presentation is structured, well-organized, and appropriately aligned with the targeted audience and the purposes of the discourse. The delivery stage brings the preparation stage to life and, even though it has its own challenges, those challenges are mostly performance-related (Author, 2020).

Second, all surveyed guidebooks pointed out the central role of the content of a presentation as a major guiding principle. In fact, no other recommendation can work if a presenter does not have something meaningful to say (Carter, 2021; Platow, 2002). As Carter (2021) put it: "The goal of designing a great presentation is not to take bad scientific content and disguise it as great. The goal is to communicate great content in a clear, succinct, and inspiring way …, to value and respect your content by presenting it in the best possible light." (p. 5).

At the same time, the different situational characteristics of a presentation setting (e.g., audience, discipline- or non-discipline-specific topic, specific communicative purpose) inevitably influence the organization of a presentation's content. For example, the content of a technical research report presented to an audience of engineers will be likely influenced by the technical nature of the research and the extent to which the audience is familiar with the topic itself. Thus, such a presentation will be expected to have all the ingredients of a research report (e.g., recognition of a problem, clearly formed research questions, description of the experimentation, data analysis, presentation of the results, conclusions and recommendations) in addition to technical details, formulas, calculations,

graphs and other pertinent technical information. If, however, a similar report is to be presented before an audience of, say, investors, then, it will probably retain some of its structure, but the technical details will likely be toned down not only to accommodate the more varied technical familiarity of the audience, but also to acknowledge that an audience of investors will most likely be looking for answers to different sets of questions compared to an audience of engineers. Equally importantly, the different audiences will also, most probably, have their own expectations about the organization of the presentation's content so that it is aligned with their schema.

Third, all surveyed sources noted the importance of keeping the audience in mind in different ways. However, dependent on whether the authors considered the preparation or the delivery stage of a presentation to be most important, they emphasized different aspects of what counted as an *effective* audience orientation of a presentation. By and large, the authors of the general guidebooks put most of their emphases on recommendations related to the performance part of a presentation to address audience accommodation. They tended to emphasize the effects of voice and volume, breathing, speech rate, enunciation, variation in speech, body language, eye-contact, facial expression, posture, movement, etc. with little to no mention of audience analysis (i.e., who the audience is) and audience needs analysis (i.e., what an audience needs to know to comprehend a presentation). In other words, those guidebooks tended to be more speaker-than listener-oriented which is probably because they were designed for a readership with no specific disciplinary affiliation.

On the other hand, guidebooks targeting more advanced students in various disciplinary areas tended to underscore the important role of audience analysis in *effective* presentations, which is usually carried out during the preparation stage and, respectively, triggers performance adjustments later on (Carter, 2021). They tended to be more listener-oriented and emphasized the importance of analyzing and keeping in mind the general expertise of the audience, its composition, values, level of topic familiarity, the language it is accustomed to, its preferences to factual information display, its expectations of (disciplinary) appropriateness in the use of different kinds of visuals (e.g., tables, figures, graphs, photographs), points that will be expected to be addressed in a presentation, possible questions that may be raised, and others. Thus, the discipline-specific guidebooks tended to highlight that doing audience analysis and keeping the audience in mind is a complex task, which requires students to think both as disciplinary insiders (as presenters) as well as disciplinary non-specialists (as listeners) when designing their presentations.

Fourth, academic presentations are necessarily highly structured because they have to be delivered within a time limit. These two characteristics of presentations always put additional pressures both on presenters as well as on listeners. So, structuring the content and organizing the discourse in disciplinary recognizable ways should be seen as opportunities to lift some of those cognitive pressures from the speakers and listeners alike. Put differently, presenters need to organize and structure their complex content so that it can fit a specified time limit which, in turn, requires them to decide and plan ahead of time what to say, how much detail to include, and what to leave out (Carter, 2021; Engleberg & Daly, 2005; Platow, 2002; Raybould, 2015; Schwabish, 2017). Importantly, an essential part of the sequencing of the informational content is to present the most powerful arguments first because they are most likely to have the greatest impact on the overall perception of the rest of the content due to the so-called primacy effect (i.e., the effect of information presented earlier compared to the effect of information presented later) (Raybould, 2015).

From a listener's perspective, it is easier to follow, understand, and recollect a well-organized presentation because the "story line" starts to flow smoothly when complex ideas are sequenced thoughtfully (Carter, 2021, Raybould, 2015, Van Emden & Becker, 2004). Additionally, several of the surveyed sources (Engleberg & Daly, 2005; Silyn-Roberts, 2002) noted the three-step organization principle "Tell'em what you're gonna tell them; tell'em; then tell'em what you told'em." Of course, there is more than the "Tell'em" strategy to a good organization of a presentation, but the important point here is that this principle of content recycling underscores the benefits of repetition and restatement of the main ideas of a presentation as an organization principle. It encourages listeners to stay focused, increases their sense of familiarity with the content, facilitates their making connections across the main ideas, and helps them remember them better (Raybould, 2015).

Fifth, another shared guiding principle of *effective* presentations across the surveyed sources was the rehearsed nature of academic presentations. All sources emphasized the importance of rehearsing a presentation thoroughly and in full, including with the use of technology and supporting prompts if used (e.g., cue cards or flashcards). Generally, rehearsals are commonly thought to benefit primarily presenters, for instance, by helping them overcome nervousness, practice speaking skills, internalize the flow of the presentation, synchronize the operation of technology with the speech delivery, boost presenters' confidence, etc. However, most guidebooks pointed out that rehearsals benefit listeners as well. For example, rehearsals help eliminate redundancies in speech and increase presenters' precision of expression which, in turn, is likely to make it easier for listeners to better comprehend the content of the presentation. Rehearsals help with the identification of content that may need to be emphasized to draw the attention of listeners to it, for example, through tone and intonation, body language, or slide design. Rehearsals also help set up an appropriate speech rate which, among other benefits, facilitates the online processing needs of listeners. Thus, given that even seasoned presenters rehearse, practicing a presentation is more than a general recommendation for novice presenters. It is the essential link between planning and performance, which also allows for final touches before the delivery of the presentation itself to the intended audience.

Sixth, communication with the audience is central to the *effectiveness* of presentations even though a presentation is a monologic discourse (Anholt, 2006; Author, 2009; Engleberg & Daly, 2005; Raybould, 2015). In regard to this principle, some of the guidebooks pointed out the distinction between presentations which are primarily performance-oriented and others which are more message-oriented (Levin & Topping, 2006; McCarthy & Hatcher, 2002). In performance-oriented presentations, the audience is assumed to be there primarily to evaluate the entertainment value of a presentation while, in the message-oriented ones, the audience is assumed to be there primarily for the message. Thus, from a listener point of view, the *success* of presentations is evaluated in different ways. That is, in the performance-oriented ones, it is evaluated by the level of entertainment and, in the message-oriented presentations—by the extent to which the listeners comprehend, value, and retain the message (Carter, 2021; McCarthy & Hatcher, 2002; Raybould, 2015; Silyn-Roberts, 2002).

The final shared core principle which contributes to the *effectiveness* of academic presentations concerned the use of technologies in ways that help enhance their comprehensibility and impact rather than overpower them. In other words, the use of technologies should facilitate the communication of a presentation's most important points and their unambiguous understanding rather than dominate it. Thus, in *effective* presentations, presenters should aim at a good balance between speech, text, and images on slides/visuals because listeners process information presented in different modalities differently, with novices to a subject area being more susceptible to modality effects than disciplinary experts (Raybould, 2015).

5. Additional aspects of *effective* and *successful* academic presentations

Besides the general core principles on which *effective* and *successful* presentations were recommended to be designed by all of the reviewed sources, the notion of *effectiveness* tended to include some additional characteristics, which were brought up in some sources but not in others. It should be noted here that few of the sources had dedicated specific writing space (e.g., paragraph/s or a section, or a chapter) to what makes a presentation *effective*. Of the fifteen surveyed guidebooks, only two addressed the notion of *effectiveness* in more specific terms—i.e., Chivers and Shoolbred (2007) dedicated a chapter to the essential principles of *effective* presentations (chapter 2 in their book), and Levin and Topping (2006) included a section on the "Ingredients of a successful presentation" (pp. 6–7). The remaining sources had spread out references to what makes a presentation *successful* or *effective* throughout their discussions. Nonetheless, even though the notion of *effectiveness* remained somewhat vague and undefined in most of the surveyed sources, they all seemed to agree that, on the one hand, *effectiveness* requires a conscious effort and, on the other—it is a cumulative outcome resulting from conscious work on each stage of the presentation.

The additional features of *effective* presentations, which will be discussed below, were identified the same way the core principles were identified. The only difference was that they were explicitly stated as contributing to the *effectiveness* or *success* of presentations either, at least, in a couple or most of the surveyed sources but not in all of them as was the case with the core principles. Those characteristics will be viewed from the point of view of the two-stage process of presentation development—the preparation and delivery stage.

5.1. Additional aspects of effectiveness related to the preparation stage of presentations

From a preparation point of view, some of the additional recommendations linked explicitly to the *success* and *effectiveness* of presentations were the following.

1) A *successful* and *effective* presentation is coherent, unfolds like a story, and holds listeners' attention by creating connections between their own experiences and the content, thus, engaging them in the logical flow of ideas (Anholt, 2006; Carter, 2021; Platow, 2002; Raybould, 2015; Van Emden & Becker, 2004). "A story has perspective, a context, a plot, and a climatic conclusion" (Anholt, 2006, p. 37). However, the elements that go into the "story" are discipline-specific. For example, some of the science-oriented presentation guidebooks (e.g., Carter, 2021; Krantz, 2017) highlighted that an *effective* science presentation is framed by the scientific method of inquiry, meaning that "there should always be a sense of the background knowledge, hypothesis/goal, methods, and discussion to frame results in a larger scientific context" (Carter, 2021, p. 202). In that sense, it looks like that, in science-oriented presentations, the recommended story line resembles very closely the main sections one can find in published quantitative studies.
2) Scientific presentations should also have scientific value by being based on evidence and its accurate interpretation (Anholt, 2006; Carter, 2021; Engleberg & Daly, 2005; Levin & Topping, 2006; McCarthy & Hatcher, 2002; Patience et al., 2015; Platow, 2002; Schwabish, 2017). Krantz (2017) further pointed out that the most important part of a technical presentation, for example, is the discussion of the results and the conclusions stemming from their interpretation. Thus, these two sections should be considered the highlight of a technical presentation.
3) Several guidebooks highlighted the importance of ethics in relation to the *effectiveness* of presentations. The ethical aspect of *effective* presentations is associated primarily with the preparation stage when important decisions are made about, for instance, the choice of credible sources as evidence, the depth and truthfulness of the analyses, the accurate interpretation of the work of others, the proper acknowledgements of all contributors to a claim or research, the proper citation of sources (Davis et al., 2012; Engleberg & Daly, 2005; McCarthy & Hatcher; 2002; Raybould, 2015). Importantly, the ethical concerns a presenter has kept in mind during the preparation stage should be conveyed to the audience during the delivery stage to establish the credibility of the information.
4) Thoughtful choice of examples during the preparation stage helps provoke interest and, more importantly, helps improve the understanding of the content of a presentation (Chivers & Shoolbred, 2007; Engleberg & Daly, 2005; Raybould, 2015). As Raybould (2015) pointed out, examples provide "hooks" for the audience which help listeners connect details from the informational content of a presentation to their own experiences so that they can better interpret the message.
5) A thoughtful design of supporting materials such as PowerPoint slides or other visuals and handouts as well as the inclusion of links to additional resources is useful during and after a presentation for both presenters and their audience (Carter, 2021; Krantz, 2017; Raybould, 2015). The important point is to design those materials around ideas and make them "idea-centric" rather than "slide-centric" (Carter, 2021. p. 187; Raybould, 2015).
6) Appropriate choice of images and visualization helps communicate information more clearly, improves understanding, increases interest, heightens the overall impact of a presentation, and saves time. For scientific and technical presentations, the

use of visuals such as diagrams, tables, graphs, and charts is an essential and expected visual display of information (Carter, 2021; Krantz, 2017; Silyn-Roberts, 2002), especially when it is more expeditious to communicate a point with such visuals rather than explain it in speech. This strategy is particularly appropriate when conveying a "big picture" concept or when sorting out data into different categories (Carter, 2021). Importantly, those visual representations need to be large enough, simple, clean, and clear rather than artistic and "noisy" (Carter, 2021; Krantz, 2017; Raybould, 2015; Silyn-Roberts, 2002).

7) One of the hallmarks of an *effective* presentation is to make the complex as simple as possible, especially in science (Carter, 2021; Krantz, 2017; Raybould, 2015). So, finding ways to filter out complexities is a challenge that is worth embracing during the preparation stage of a presentation. As Carter (2021) put it: "Sometimes the genius of a good science presentation is what you choose to leave out rather than what you choose to include" (p. 15).
8) Careful use of specialized language includes predicting the terminology with which the audience is likely to be familiar while avoiding or explaining specialist acronyms and jargon with which it may not be familiar. In instances of novel terms and vocabulary, explanations and/or novel interpretations should be added unambiguously (Anholt, 2006; Carter, 2021; Chivers & Shoolbred, 2007; Davis et al., 2012; Engleberg & Daly, 2005; Levin & Topping, 2006; Patience et al., 2015; Raybould, 2015; Reinhart, 2002).
9) Clarity should be evident both at the level of preparation as well as delivery:
   a) Clarity of structure helps facilitate listeners' comprehension of the content of a presentation on many levels (Carter, 2021; Chivers & Shoolbred, 2007; Davis et al., 2012; Engleberg & Daly, 2005; Krantz, 2017; Patience et al., 2015; Schwabish, 2017; Silyn-Roberts, 2002).
   b) Clarity of visual display is achieved through the use of uncluttered visuals, which helps communicate complex informational content to listeners in a more explicit way (Anholt, 2006; Carter, 2021; Raybould, 2015; Schwabish, 2017; Silyn-Roberts, 2002).
   c) Clarity of speech is primarily achieved through rehearsal of a presentation. It is not only an expected quality of an *effective* presentation, but it is also central to attending well to listeners' processing needs (Engleberg & Daly, 2005; McCarthy & Hatcher, 2002), especially when presenters' speech is accented (Raybould, 2015).
10) Commitment to consistency (e.g., consistent use of color, font, font size, visual organization of the information, bullet points, figures, graphs, tables, the use of verb tenses, punctuation) is a strategy that helps optimize the clarity and legibility of the text on visuals. It makes a presentation visually more attractive (Carter, 2021; Krantz, 2017). It also creates a sense of visual familiarity that acts as a backdrop against which novelty can stand out (Raybould, 2015).

5.2. Additional aspects of effectiveness related to the delivery stage of presentations

From a delivery point of view, the number of characteristics linked to the notion of *effective* and *successful* presentations was more varied. Both some of the general and the area-specific guidebooks noted a number of select characteristics linked to *effectiveness*, including the following recommendations.

1) Deliver the message persuasively to engage the audience with the presenter's viewpoints and stances (Anholt, 2006; Carter, 2021; Chivers & Shoolbred, 2007; Davis et al., 2012; Krantz, 2017; Levin & Topping, 2006; McCarthy & Hatcher, 2002; Platow, 2002; Raybould, 2015; Schwabish, 2017; Silyn-Roberts, 2002).
2) Deliver the message eloquently to show variability in language choices but aim for language that conveys simplicity and precision (Carter, 2021; Raybould, 2015).
3) Deliver the presentation enthusiastically and energetically to make the audience connect to the presenter's involvement with the content, their excitement, confidence, and persistence (Krantz, 2017; Raybould, 2015).
4) Deliver the presentation without reading too much from the slides on the screen to show mastery of the presentation's content (Carter, 2021) and confidence (Raybould, 2015) while keeping the audience engaged.
5) Speak naturally and, ideally, at a controlled speech rate—e.g., some guidebooks recommended a speech rate of about 140–150 words per minute (Patience et al., 2015). Others recommended practicing to keep even a slower speaking rate to allow the audience to adjust to a presenter's accent regardless of whether they are L1 or L2 speakers of English (Krantz, 2017; Reinhart, 2002). Generally, complex content coupled with a fast delivery pace can potentially overwhelm listeners (Patience et al., 2015).
6) Use appropriate non-verbal communication, usually associated with presenters' physical appearance, facial expressions, eye contact, use of body language, volume, vocal emphasis, etc., since non-verbal communication greatly contributes to the intended interpretation of a message and carries meaning beyond language use alone. Non-verbal communication also conveys a wealth of information about the presenters themselves. Interestingly, though, while some of the general guidebooks recommended to always smile at the audience and think of it as "friends" (e.g., Raybould, 2015; Van Emden & Becker, 2004) or smile to combat nervousness (Krantz, 2017), some of the guidebooks designed for the technical fields advised against smiling (Silyn-Roberts, 2002). This implies that different disciplinary areas may have differing preferences for non-verbal communication, and novice presenters would need to become aware of those preferences either by observing seasoned presenters in their disciplines or by inquiring about what is considered acceptable in their field of study.
7) Maintain strong audience orientation—for example, Levin and Topping (2006) underscored that "a successful presentation is not only given to the audience, it is given for the audience. It certainly isn't just a speech launched in the general direction of the audience with a 'take it or leave it' attitude" (p. 4). In *successful* presentations, presenters transport their audience to a shared understanding of the main ideas of a presentation. In other words, to maintain good audience orientation, "speakers must structure

their presentations in such a way that listeners are clearly led from word to image, image to idea, idea to concept" (McCarthy & Hatcher, 2002, p. 70). Importantly, the content of the presentation should be carefully matched not only to a presenter's purpose but also to the listeners' characteristics, values, expectations, and needs, especially if a presentation is given in a culturally diverse context (Engleberg & Daly, 2005; Krantz, 2017; McCarthy & Hatcher, 2002; Raybould, 2015; Van Emden & Becker, 2004).

8) Consider thoughtfully the relationship between slides and oral delivery, at least, in two ways: First, during a slide presentation, listeners receive information simultaneously from two sources—the presenter's speech and the slides; thus, the narration and visuals should always complement each other (Carter, 2021; Krantz, 2017). Second, it is acceptable to orally discuss information without representing it on a slide while, in contrast, everything visually displayed on a slide should be discussed in delivery, which suggests that slides should be free of visual redundancies (Carter, 2021; Krantz, 2017; Raybould, 2015).

As it can be seen, the list of additional recommendations that make academic presentations *effective* and *successful* is quite extensive, and the recommendations are associated with both the preparation and delivery stage of presentations. The list provides a summary of the key ways *effectiveness* can be achieved, which can help instructors address each stage separately and heighten novice presenters' awareness of how work on each of the stages would benefit both presenters and listeners. Needless to say, disciplinary specificities should also be addressed in presentation guidelines because, as the survey revealed, there were some subtle area-specific differences which would be useful to highlight in discussions about presentations. This could be done either by non-disciplinary instructors in consultation with disciplinary specialists or by encouraging novice presenters to observe and/or talk to disciplinary specialists about presentation specificities related to their areas of study. After all, the more students are consciously aware of the qualities that impact the *effectiveness* of their presentations, the more educated they will be as listeners of the presentations of others' (Author, 2020).

6. Language data sources behind the language recommendations of the surveyed guidebooks

The last aspect of interest the survey addressed was the extent to which the language recommendations the authors suggested in their guidebooks were based on large data source/s of naturally produced language like corpora or primarily on the authors' personal observations on language used in presentations. By and large, all of the surveyed sources touched upon some aspects of language use to a certain extent—some provided more elaborate discussions, others did so in passing. For instance, Reinhart's (2002) guidebook offered strong emphases on language use for various presentation purposes such as opening and closing a speech, description of objects and processes, relevant language for presenter-listener interaction, discussion of fillers, etc. It also introduced presenters to the discourse utility of some rhetorical and grammatical structures like the use of modal verbs, linking adverbials, tense, voice, different types of sentences, etc. McCarthy and Hatcher (2002) dedicated a chapter to language use in their guidebook (chapter 6) where they elaborated on the positive effects of a number of language features, ranging from the choice of precise vocabulary to using rhetoric strategically in presentations. Engleberg and Daly (2005) devoted a chapter with language recommendations (chapter 12) mostly about engaging the audience with the purpose of the presentation. Several of the other guidebooks had, at best, a section dedicated to specific language recommendations about making a presentation audience-friendly (e.g., Levin & Topping, 2006) or discussed briefly a comparison between formal and speech style language use (e.g., Silyn-Roberts, 2002). However, the majority of the surveyed guidebooks addressed only occasionally language features typically found in academic presentations, perhaps, because the authors assumed that their targeted readers are fully linguistically aware of the language accommodations they need to make for presentation purposes.

In my experience, this is a slippery assumption when it comes to novice presenters regardless of whether they are L1 or L2 users of English. In most cases, students who are presentation neophytes may be aware of certain general language recommendations at a sentence level, such as to divide long and complex sentences into shorter ones, to avoid sentence fragments and use complete sentences instead, to use different types of sentences for interest and emphasis, to use figurative language sparingly, etc. However, their theoretical and/or implicit awareness does not necessarily result in consistent application of this kind of knowledge to their language choices unless students are guided and prompted to do so. Same is true of the general vocabulary recommendations. Overall, the authors who offered vocabulary advice urged the presenters to explain specialized terminology and acronyms, to avoid jargon, to choose their vocabulary with precision and in favor of more common words than "pretentious or pompous" vocabulary, etc. While these are all relevant recommendations, they still remain largely vague unless students know what exactly they stand for so that they can act on the advice. In that sense, I believe that a focus on language use for presentation purposes will not only make novice presenters more linguistically educated about how specific language choices contribute to the *effectiveness* of presentations but will also encourage them to start using certain language features to that effect intentionally rather than intuitively.

As far as whether the language recommendations in the surveyed guidebooks were based on generalizable data sources or not, only Reinhart's (2002) guidebook was based on corpus data of oral academic discourse, and the language examples came from the Michigan Corpus of Academic Spoken English (MICASE) (Simpson et al., 2002). In my view, this corpus-based approach to offering language advice not only gives credibility to the recommendations but also ensures that students from different disciplinary areas can put their trust in that the recommended language is not subjective or biased in any way. The rest of the surveyed guidebooks included language examples mostly as sentence frames (e.g., to introduce a presenter, to ask for clarification, to request questions from the audience at the end of a presentation) which, in the absence of any references to a specific language source, can be safely assumed to be based on the authors' personal language observations and experiences. Needless to say, those observations are a valuable source of information. However, when language recommendations are exclusively based on personal experiences, it limits their value to the author's subjective authority on language matters. Perhaps, a reasonable approach to language recommendations in both general and area-specific presentation guidebooks would be to provide a healthy mix of corpus-based and research-based language advice alongside personal

observations. Such an approach will highlight the fact that the language of academic presentations contains commonalities, which necessarily need to be complemented by area-specific language choices to bring both presenters and listeners to a common space of mutual understanding.

7. Concluding remarks

By surveying guidebooks designed for a general academic readership and ones designed primarily for specific scientific and technical communities, one of the objectives of this survey was to examine how Anglophone academic culture views the notion of *effectiveness* of academic presentations and, consequently, determine shared core principles which contribute to it. It was also of interest to identify additional explicitly stated aspects of *effective* and *successful* presentations, some of which are more commonly shared across the surveyed sources and others which may be more area-specific. Finally, to get a better sense of the generalizability of the language recommendations the presentation guidebooks suggested, the survey looked into whether they were derived from large language data sources like corpora or whether they were based primarily on the authors' personal experiences.

Several findings emerged from the survey. The first one was that Anglophone academic culture has a consistent view of several core principles on which *effective* and *successful* academic presentations should be built despite differences in the targeted readership. In other words, all of the surveyed sources explicitly associated the *effectiveness* of presentations with a number of core principles guiding their development and delivery. This implies that the notion of *effectiveness* is fairly well-defined in Anglophone academic culture and, in that, it offers a workable framework for both instructors and students, L1 or L2 users of English alike. Notably, though, few of the sources have dedicated a specific space to what makes academic presentations *effective,* which mostly leaves it to the readers to put the puzzle together and figure out the order of priority in all of the proposed recommendations.

Along with the recommended core principles for developing *effective* and *successful* presentations, there were also some additional characteristics which were less consistently noted in the surveyed sources. Nonetheless, there was a unanimous agreement that those additional characteristics are associated with both the preparation and delivery stage in the development of a presentations, thus, its *success* cannot be attributed to any one of the stages alone. It should also be noted that, depending on whether the surveyed guidebooks were designed for general or area-specific audiences, there was a slight variation among them in the list of additional desirable characteristics they proposed. In that sense, when non-disciplinary specialists are teaching presentation skills, it would be important to encourage novice presenters to observe and/or talk to disciplinary specialists about presentation specificities in their area of specialization so that they get a well-rounded view of what makes a presentation *effective* in their area-specific context.

Finally, the investigation into the language recommendations in the surveyed sources revealed that, firstly, all of the surveyed sources touched upon aspects of language use to some extent. However, most of them addressed language features typical of academic presentations sporadically, perhaps, because the authors assumed that their targeted readership is linguistically educated—an assumption which seems unfounded on many levels. Secondly, in terms of whether or not the language recommendations the authors proposed were based on large data source/s of naturally produced language, the survey revealed that, with the exception of one guidebook, the rest of the surveyed sources offered primarily the authors' subjective views on language. As valuable as those views can be, a more useful approach would be to incorporate into the language recommendations research findings on the language of academic presentations, corpus-based recommendations as well as personal language observations, especially in area-specific contexts. Such an approach will put into use all relevant sources of language advice for presentation purposes instead of relying on subjective observations and personal experiences alone. Thirdly, the treatment of the language of academic presentations noticeably lacked sufficient depth and breadth in most of the guidebooks, which suggested that language use was designated a somewhat secondary role when it comes to its contribution to the *effectiveness* of presentations. I believe that a focus on language use for presentation purposes will not only make novice presenters more linguistically educated about how specific language choices contribute to the *success* of their presentations, but will also encourage them to plan on using certain language features to that effect intentionally and purposefully.

On a final note, by surveying a mix of general and area-specific guidebooks on academic presentations, my hope was not only to uncover the "content" behind the notion of *effective* and *successful* presentations as perceived by Anglophone academic culture, but also to identify the most desirable characteristics contributing to it. Ideally, all these aspects can be of practical value to instructors in higher education (EAP, ESAP and area specialists alike) to give helpful guidelines and design appropriate grading rubrics and/or checklists for their presentation assignments. They should also be beneficial to students in guiding them in all the right directions as presenters.

CRediT authorship contribution statement

Alla Zareva: Writing – original draft.

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